Merz calls for trade deal with Asia-Pacific CPTPP group

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Merz calls for trade deal with Asia-Pacific CPTPP group
By Hans von der Burchard, Romanus Otte · Oct 27, 2026, 2:56 PM · View in your browser

SINGAPORE — German Chancellor Friedrich Merz called on Tuesday for the European Union to reach a free-trade agreement with a leading Asia-Pacific group as he started a regional tour to drum up trade and investment.

Speaking in Singapore, Merz said a deal with the CPTPP, also known as the Trans-Pacific Partnership, could serve as a stepping stone toward an eventual accord with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, with which its membership partly overlaps.

“Let us work together toward a major interregional agreement with the members of the Trans-Pacific Partnership,” he said in a keynote address.

The CPTPP comprises 12 member states on both sides of the Pacific, as well as the United Kingdom. Together, the EU and the CPTPP would form the world’s largest transnational free- trade zone, encompassing more than a billion people. Merz noted that the two blocs combined would account for more than a third of global trade.

He proposed linking the EU’s existing bilateral trade agreements to increase their efficiency, name-checking existing or prospective deals with Indonesia, the Philippines, India, Australia and Malaysia. “I do not want us to stop here,” Merz said. “In the long term, we are aiming for a free-trade agreement between the EU and ASEAN.”

His speech in Singapore set the framework for the chancellor’s longest foreign tour to date, which will take him to Japan and South Korea before concluding on Friday. Beyond trade, Merz is focused on fostering closer cooperation on security, raw materials and high tech.

Merz’s appeal to strike a deal with the CPTPP — whose full name is the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership — comes as the EU steps up its engagement with the like-minded market democracies that it sees as regional counterweights to China.

Germany recently became the last EU country to slide into a bilateral trade deficit with China, its automakers outcompeted by the cheaper, more advanced electric vehicles made there. At the same time as Merz is touring the region, German President Frank-Walter Steinmeier is on a state visit to China.

The current era of great-power politics also opens new doors for the EU and other middle powers, Merz argued. “We are building a network of partners with whom we share fundamental values and interests,” he said. “This new era is bringing us closer together than ever before.”

China’s role raises “profound questions regarding trade, security and the international order,” he added, while rejecting the idea of decoupling from the world’s second-largest economy as a grave mistake.

“It would make us neither more secure nor more prosperous.”

Trade Mobility Trade UK
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